

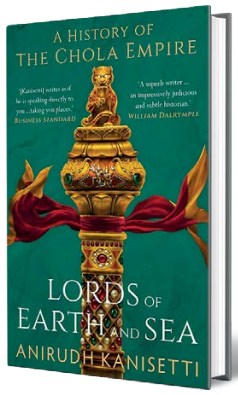
BOOKS

RISE AND FALL OF AN EMPIRE

Anirudh Kanisetti's monumental history of the Cholas is here

The Cholas stand out amongst numerous dynasties who jostle for our attention in ancient and medieval India. Starting from their core in the Kaveri delta, their empire at its peak covered a large chunk of peninsular India, both its coasts and also expanded into the Deccan. Their campaigns extended much further to the north to reach the Ganges in Bengal; Rajendra Chola bore the title 'Conqueror of the Ganges'. Their maritime excursions and ambitions also mark them out as one of the very few who breached the continental confines of most Indian dynasties. The Cholas had a long-standing presence in Lanka and campaigned there frequently. Rajendra Chola, even more spectacularly, raided the coasts of the Malay peninsula across the Bay of Bengal. But their greatest feuds were with their neighbours—the Pandyas, the Chalukyas, the Hoysalas—whom they first regularly defeated but were, in the end, vanquished by.

The rise and ebb of the Cholas is the story of Kanisetti's book. His treatment covers many other aspects beyond the military and political to give us more rounded and granular perspectives. Thus, the Cholas stand out also because they were master builders. During their reign, the entire aesthetic of South Indian architecture changed and arguably their greatest emperors, Rajaraja and Rajendra, stand out as much for their grand temples as for their conquests.



LORDS OF EARTH AND SEA: A History of the Chola Empire
by Anirudh Kanisetti
JUGGERNAUT
₹**899; 376** pages

The Chola story in Kanisetti's narrative is one of how piety, faith and monumental temple building fused with military prowess and geopolitical ambition. Their maritime footprint owed much to their links with powerful Tamil merchant corporations; trade and flag fused, but it was largely trade that led the way.

Yet not all Chola rulers were entirely convinced that war and conquest were the best way to ensure their prosperity and longevity. A number of them favoured a more inward-looking agrarian stabilisation. Both approaches, Kanisetti's analysis suggests, faced an intrinsic drawback. The problem the later Cholas faced was one which their own success was partially responsible for: the growth of local magnates who in time became alternative centres of power that ended up eroding Chola rule and legitimacy.

Those who enjoyed Kanisetti's earlier work on the Deccan will not be disappointed with the Cholas. He writes with dramatic force but is respectful about the empirical evidence. Some, and not just the purists, may cavil at his frequent resort to the fly-on-the-wall technique of depicting historical events as they unfold. The Cholas are after all sufficiently dramatic not to require extra flourishes. But Kanisetti's speculations are generally well-informed and usually derived from some primary source. His narration brings this dynasty to life, cutting a firm narrative thread through a thick jungle. ■

– T.C.A. Raghavan

Kanisetti's treatment covers many other aspects **BEYOND THE MILITARY AND POLITICAL** to give us more rounded and granular perspectives